

UAE's rich heritage

Development has taken place on an unprecedented scale in the UAE and there is a deep awareness that the traditions that were the mainstay of past generations may be lost in the clamour of modern life. Therefore, preserving this cultural legacy and introducing the youth of today to the customs of their resilient forefathers is a crucial component of UAE government strategy. As a visit to a local school, feast or festival is likely to confirm, Emirati music, dance, poetry, story-telling, and heritage sports such as falconry, camel-racing and sailing are alive and well.

A key part of the preservation process has involved making sure that physical evidence of the UAE's rich heritage is not lost and conservation of many of its unique archaeological and architectural sites and its manuscripts has been given top priority. Literature and customs are widely studied in schools, while museum displays, heritage villages and the rebuilding of vanished monuments have helped to create a context and feel for this cultural legacy.



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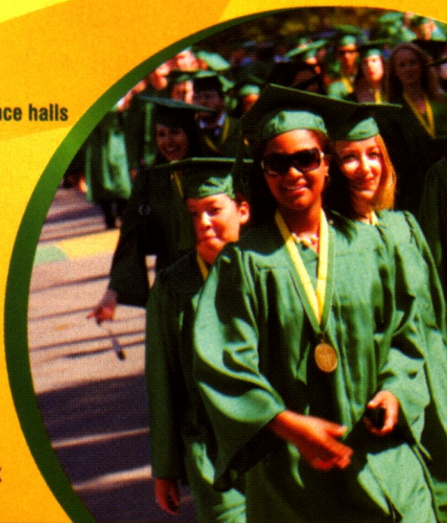
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FACTFILE

The United Arab Emirates is a federation of seven emirates (Abu Dhabi, Dubai, Sharjah, Ajman, Umm al-Qaiwain, Ra's al-Khaimah and Fujairah).

CAPITAL CITY: Abu Dhabi

NATIONAL DAY: Independence Day, 2 December (1971)

TIME: four hours ahead of GMT

CURRENCY: Emirati dirham (Dh or AED)

EXCHANGE RATE: Dh3.67 per US dollar. The UAE dirham has been officially pegged to the US dollar since February 2002.

FLAG: three equal horizontal bands of green (top), white, and black with a wider vertical red band on the hoist side

LOCATION: Situated towards the south-east of the Arabian Peninsula, the UAE is a roughly triangular landmass whose coastlines form the south and southeastern shores of the Arabian Gulf and part of the western shores of the Gulf of Oman. The UAE also has land borders with Oman and Saudi Arabia.

AREA: approximately 82,880 square kilometres. Abu Dhabi accounts for 87 per cent of the country's total landmass.

COASTLINE: prior to construction of the 'Dubai Palms' and other schemes, the coastline of the UAE was approximately 1318 kilometres. Land reclamation projects are extending this figure.

CLIMATE: the UAE enjoys a desert climate, warm and sunny in winter, hot and humid during the summer months. It is generally cooler in the eastern mountains.

INTERNATIONAL COUNTRY CODE: 971

INTERNET COUNTRY CODE: ae

INDUSTRIES: oil & gas, aluminum, cement, fertilisers, commercial ship repair, petrochemicals, construction materials, pharmaceuticals, food processing, tourism

WEEKEND: Friday and Saturday for government institutions; many private companies operate a six-day week.

FISCAL YEAR: 1 January to 31 December

GDP (est. 2006, nominal): Dh599 billion

Real GDP growth (est. 2006): 8.9%